

Making the Newsletter

Mendocino County Art Association

Everything happens in one window

In the newsletter folder there is a program called **MCAA Newsletter**. Double-click it.

It shows three steps and lights up whichever one you need next. You cannot do them in the wrong order — the other two stay greyed out until it is their turn.

If you are ever unsure where you are, just open the program. It reads the folder and tells you what has been done and what has not. It is safe to open as often as you like.

The three steps

1. Start the newsletter

Pick the month at the top of the window, then click **Start this newsletter**.

This makes your own copy to work in and offers to open it in Word. The copy lives in the **Drafts** folder and has *DRAFT* in its name, so there is never a question about which file you are editing.

Then do the month's work in Word exactly as you always have — change the date in the green bar, swap the photos, update the sidebar lists, paste in the submissions.

2. Check the photos and make the PDF

When the newsletter is finished, **save it and close Word**, then click **Check and make the PDF**.

The program looks at every photo first. If any of them have been squashed or stretched, it shows you which ones and offers to put them right — you will see each photo, so there is no guessing about which is which. Say yes and it fixes them. Nothing else on the page moves.

Then it makes the PDF and puts it in the Drafts folder next to the newsletter. Have a look at it before going on.

3. Publish

Click **Publish**. Both files — the Word document and the PDF — are saved into the **Published** folder, and that is the issue done.

The PDF is copied exactly as you saw it. The Word file is tidied up on the way in, which makes it a good deal smaller without changing a single thing on the page.

One question it will ask. There is a tick box offering to start next month from this issue. Leave it alone unless you mean it. Ticked, next month begins as a copy of the issue you just published, so you would be editing over this month's articles. Either way, the two published files are saved.

About photos

The program now handles the size problem for you. When you publish, it saves every photo at printing size and throws away the extra copies Word makes. That used to be the thing that grew the newsletter to 200 megabytes, and it is now taken care of without you doing anything.

A photo straight off a phone is about 4,000 pixels wide. On the page it prints about an inch and a half, so almost all of it is data nobody ever sees.

A REAL PHOTO FROM THE SEPTEMBER ISSUE	SIZE
As it went in — 4284 × 5712, saved as PNG	26.4 MB
As it is published, at printing size	0.45 MB

Side by side on the printed page, they look the same. Your working copy in the Drafts folder keeps the photos exactly as you put them in, so nothing is ever lost.

One habit still worth having

Big photos make **Word itself slow** while you are working — opening and saving a newsletter full of them can take minutes on a busy month. The program cannot help with that, because it only tidies up at the end.

So if a month is feeling sluggish, shrink the photos before you insert them. Install **Microsoft PowerToys** — free, and from Microsoft. It adds a *Resize pictures* option when you right-click photos in a folder. Select the month's photos, right-click, choose **Large**. It makes copies, so your originals are never touched.

Either way, use **Insert** → **Picture** rather than pasting straight out of an email.

And when you place them

When you resize a photo in Word, **drag a corner, never a side**. Dragging the handle on a side or the top squashes the picture out of shape.

The program does catch these — step 2 finds them and offers to fix them — but it is easier on everyone if they never happen.

Asking contributors for photos

The easiest version of this problem is the one that never arrives. Something like this in the submissions email helps:

"Photos are welcome — please send them as JPEG, and if your phone or email offers a size when you attach them, Medium or Large is perfect. Full size is more than the newsletter can use."

Most phone mail apps offer exactly that choice, and most people pick the smaller option if asked.

If something is not right

"Please close the newsletter in Word first." Word still has the file open. Save, close Word completely, and click the button again.

A step is greyed out. It is not its turn yet. The step above it has not been done for the month showing at the top of the window — check that the right month is selected.

Anything else. The program will not change anything it is not sure about, so a message on the screen means nothing has been damaged. Ring Kyle and read him the message.

Your work is never thrown away. The Drafts folder keeps your working copy even after you publish, and every issue that has ever gone out is in the Published folder.